condemnation of the electoral scam and the amount of global coverage of the pro-democracy efforts led the student leaders to believe that aid and military assistance would easily be secured. This assistance never materialized in any significant way. The students who headed to the border areas were not accustomed to the very difficult living conditions in the jungle and mountain regions. The harsh conditions led to widespread disease, especially malaria. Furthermore, the student organizations were beset with extreme factionalism. This problem plagued the pro-democracy movement dating back to its origins in 1988.

The insurgents also found it difficult to work with the new arrivals. The student resistance members were neither used to the harsh conditions nor were they trained to fight. They quickly became a liability. Within a few months, many students took an offer of amnesty from the tatmadaw and returned to their home provinces. Unfortunately, many were imprisoned after surrendering to the authorities. Others fled to Thailand and eventually migrated to the West, settling in the United States, Canada, and Western Europe. This subsequently led to a brain drain in which many of the best and brightest young men and women from Myanmar fled abroad because of the lack of opportunity in their home country.

The DAB included nearly 20 organizations. Only two major groups, the Communist Party of Burma and the Mong Tai Army (Shan state), remained out of the coalition. The ultimate goal was to have a true federalist system for Myanmar. Unfortunately, most groups within the coalition remained on the periphery of society, unable to make any sort of inroads within the main population centers in Myanmar. The government also started offering concessions to numerous ethnic insurgents. Rebels who signed ceasefire agreements in many cases would be permitted to keep their weapons. By granting more autonomy to local groups, SLORC bought time to take care of more serious insurgent threats to the regime.

Insurgents were permitted to maintain cross-border trade in everything from timber to precious gems. A growing dark side of the trade included an expansion of opium production and distribution to the thriving sex-trade in which young Burmese girls would be sold into slavery in Thailand and elsewhere. A significant blow to the antigovernment insurgents was the implosion of the Burmese Communist Party (BCP). As global communism was waning, the communist party no longer received backing from China.